



## **Between sustainability ambitions and market constraints: stabilizing regional food supply under competing institutional logics**

Eric Kamgang  
Laval university, Quebec, Canada

### **Abstract**

Regional food supply is increasingly mobilized as a lever for the transition toward more sustainable food systems, particularly in relation to climate issues, territorial resilience, and the support of local economies. Despite growing interest and public support, many initiatives struggle to stabilize over time as a mode of supplying professional markets, which are structured by dominant economic, regulatory, and professional requirements. This study examines the conditions under which these initiatives can stabilize within this context. Drawing on the institutional logics perspective, it analyzes the articulation of heterogeneous principles such as economic efficiency, standardization, regulatory compliance, territorial anchoring, and environmental sustainability. The analysis is based on 36 interviews conducted with actors from the food system in Québec (Canada). The findings highlight the coexistence of multiple logics and the presence of structuring tensions, particularly related to price, volumes, logistics, and standardization. These tensions constrain the integration of sustainability objectives, including those related to reducing environmental impacts. The study identifies key organizational mechanisms (intermediation, logistics coordination, and resource mutualization) that support critical functions such as supply aggregation, order management, delivery planning, and commercial interfacing. The degree of integration of these functions conditions both the stabilization of initiatives and their ability to meet the requirements of professional markets. These results show that the contribution of regional food supply to sustainability and climate-related challenges relies on the ability to develop integrated and coordinated organizational arrangements over time.

### **Biography**

Eric Kamgang is a PhD candidate at Université Laval (Québec, Canada) and a member of the Canada Research Chair on the Internalization of Sustainable Development and Organizational Accountability. His research focuses on responsible sourcing in the agri-food sector, with a particular interest in the governance of food systems. He primarily uses qualitative approaches to analyze organizational and institutional dynamics. He also contributes to teaching activities and the dissemination of knowledge in the field of sustainable development.

### **Presenting author details**

Full name: Samuel Eric Kamgang

Contact number: + 1 418 473 5521

Linked In account: <https://www.linkedin.com/in/samuel-kamgang-22792873/>

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